

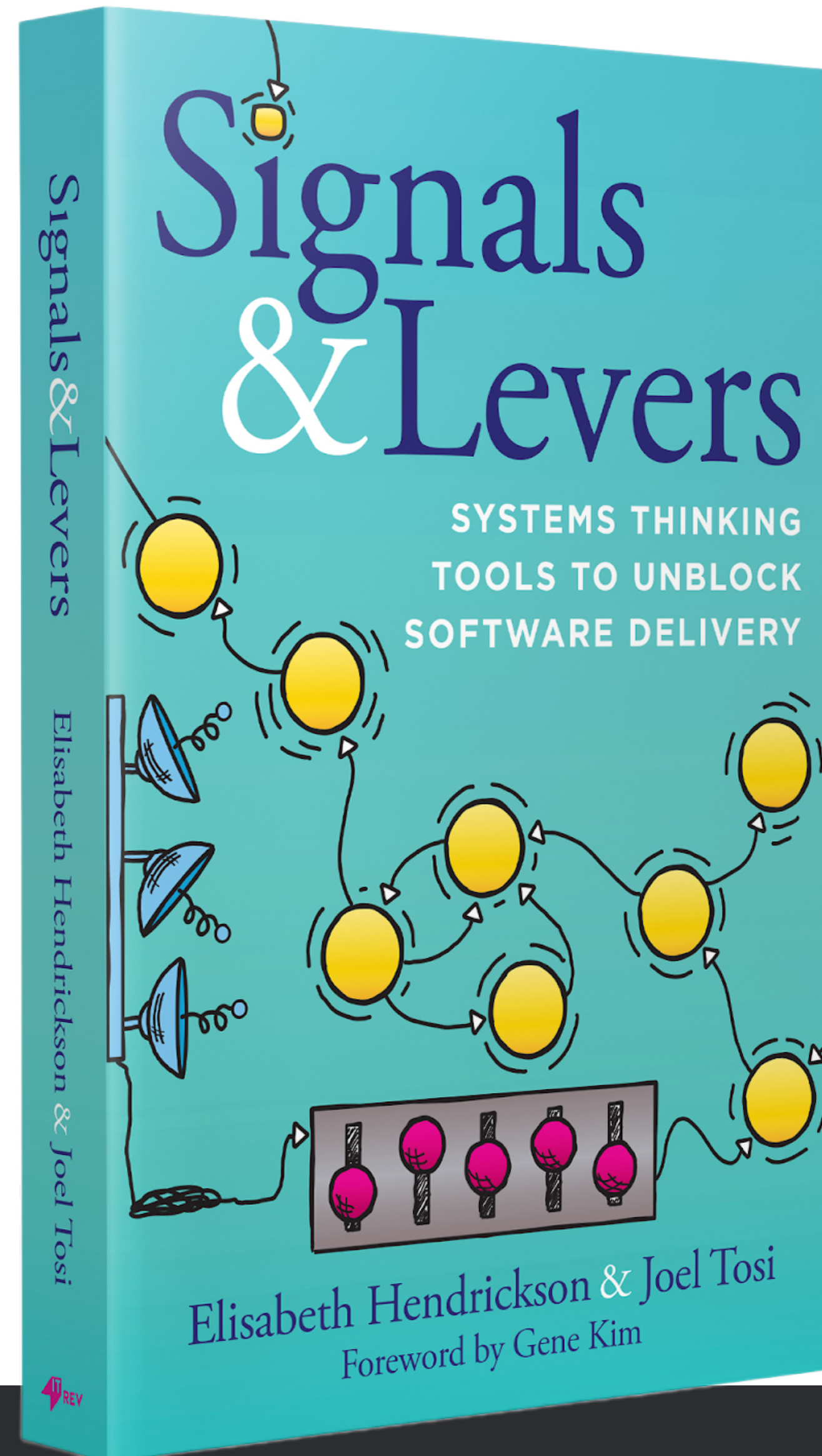
The System Pokes Back

Elisabeth Hendrickson

IT Revolution Enterprise AI Summit
October 7-8, 2026
Charlotte, NC

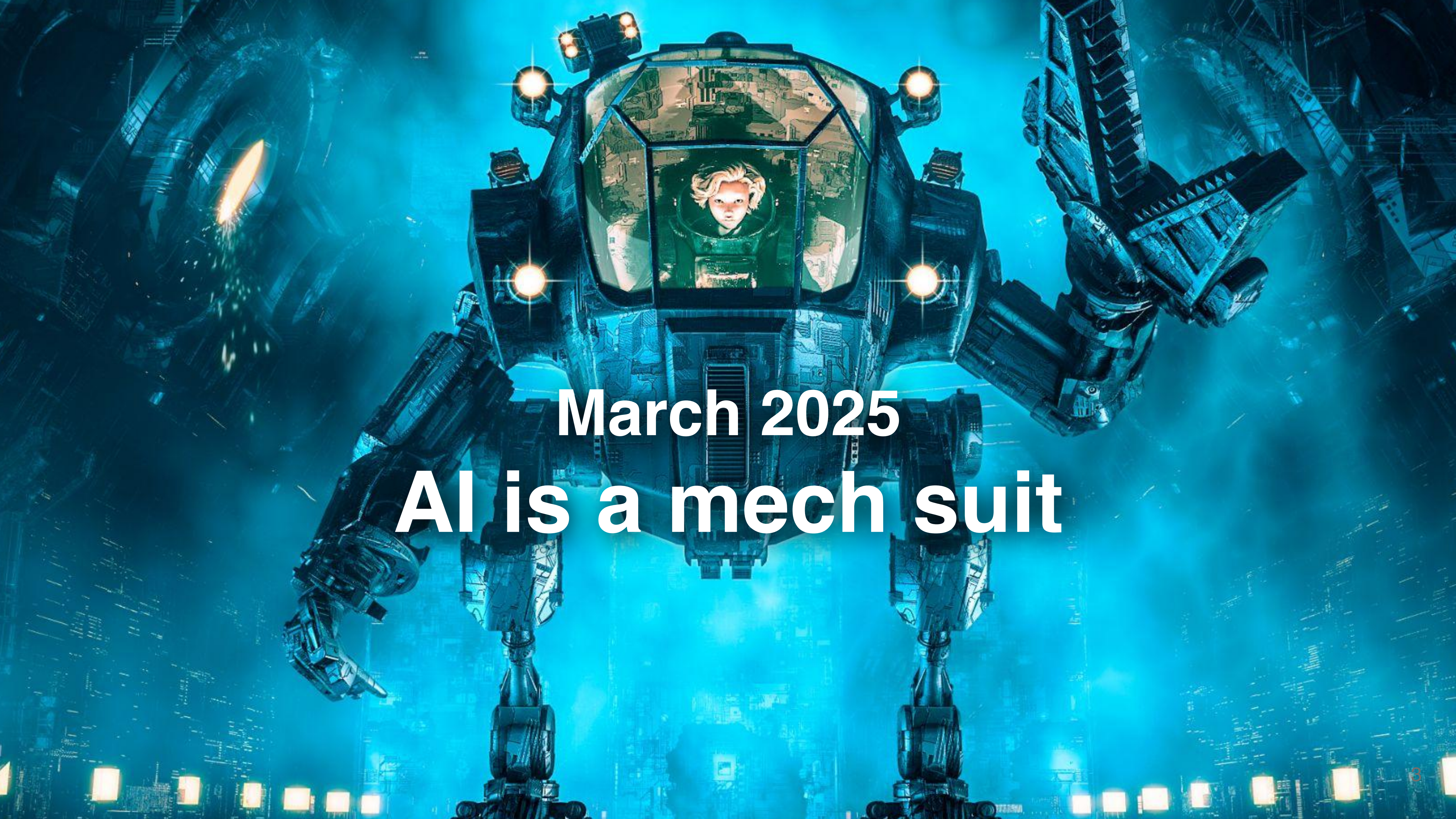
portions of this material are from the book...

*Elisabeth
Hendrickson*



Joel Tosi



A large, blue-toned mecha suit is the central focus, with a pilot visible in the cockpit. The suit is surrounded by a complex, futuristic environment with glowing lights and mechanical structures. The text "March 2025" and "AI is a mech suit" is overlaid in the center.

March 2025
AI is a mech suit

A person stands in the foreground, looking out at a futuristic city at night. The city is filled with glowing yellow and orange lights, creating a bokeh effect. The background is dark with silhouettes of buildings and structures. The overall atmosphere is futuristic and high-tech.

October 2026
**AI powers agentic
software factories**

“A small group of top performers is shipping faster and more reliably than ever, but most teams are experiencing the opposite.”

CircleCI—*2026 State of Software Delivery*



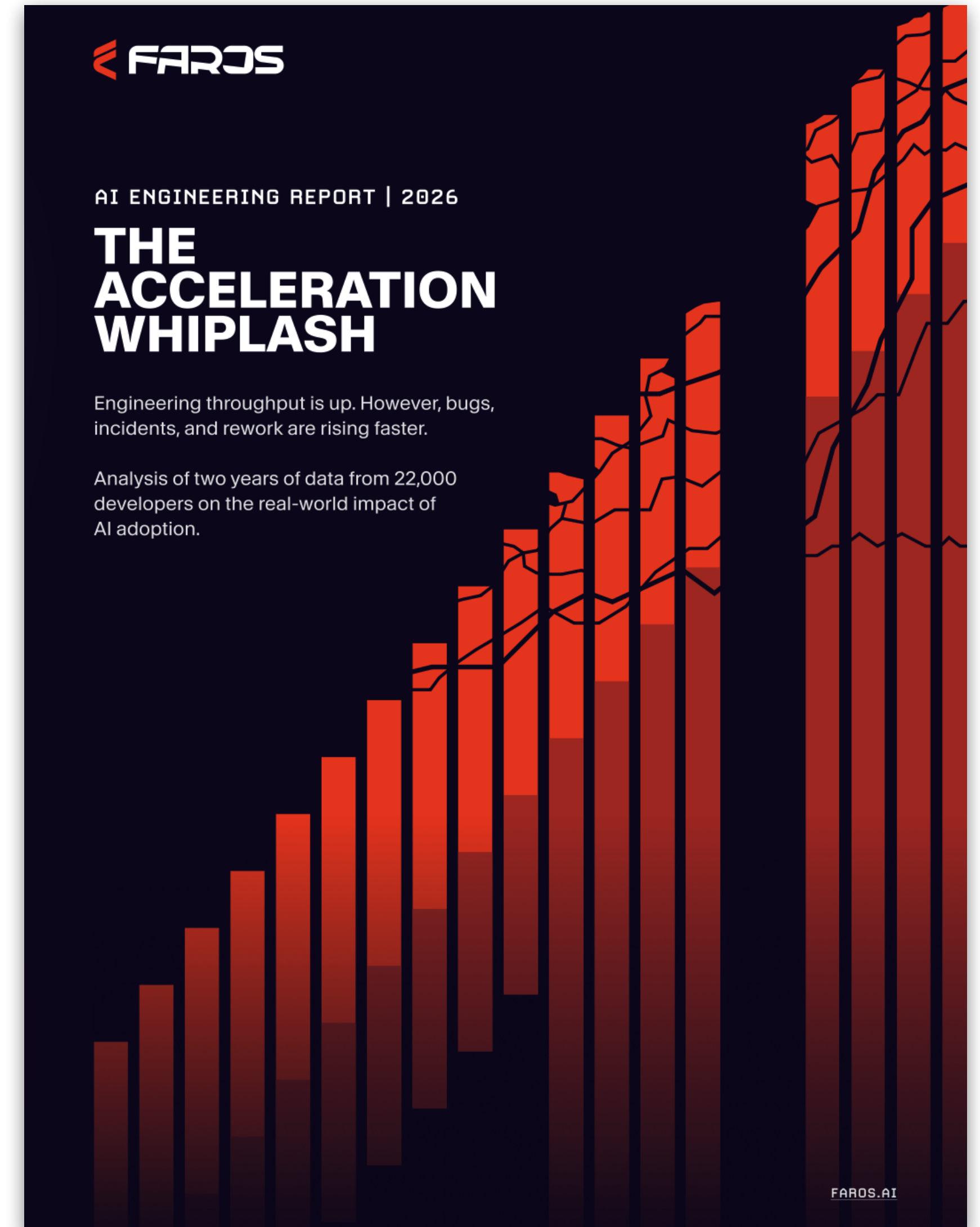
28.7M CI workflows



Illusions

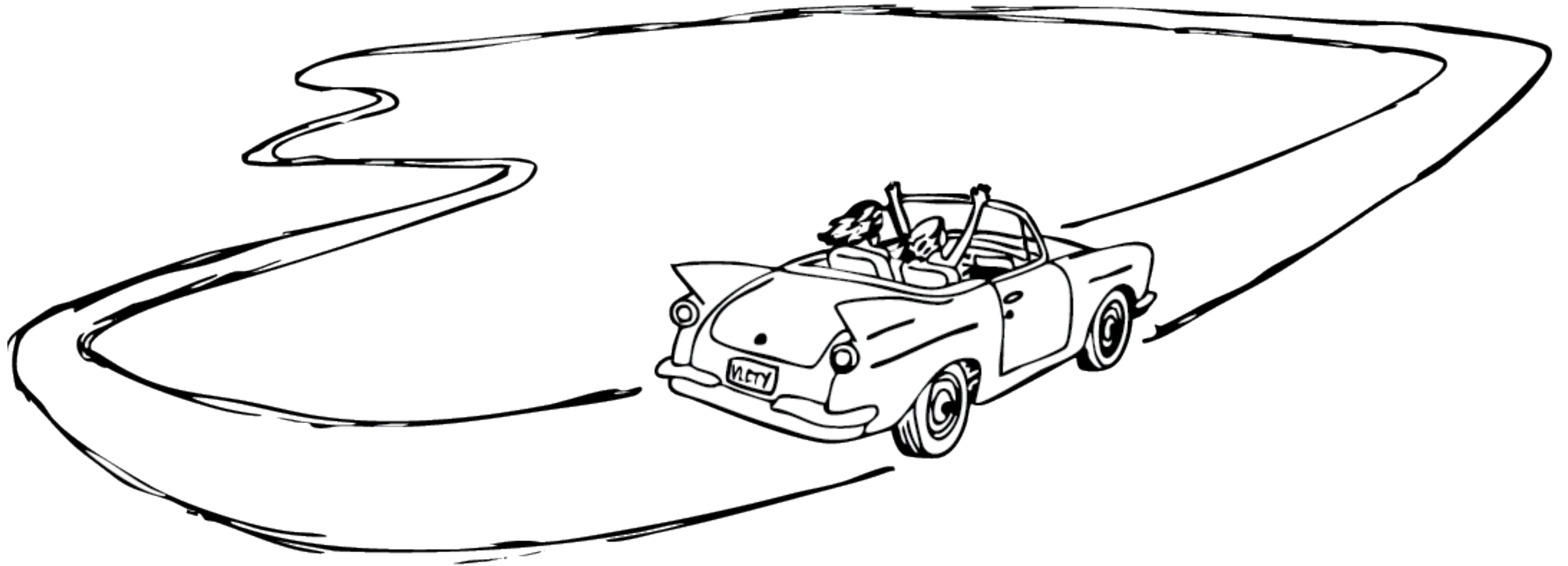
“AI made it easy to start work. It did not make it easy to finish it.”

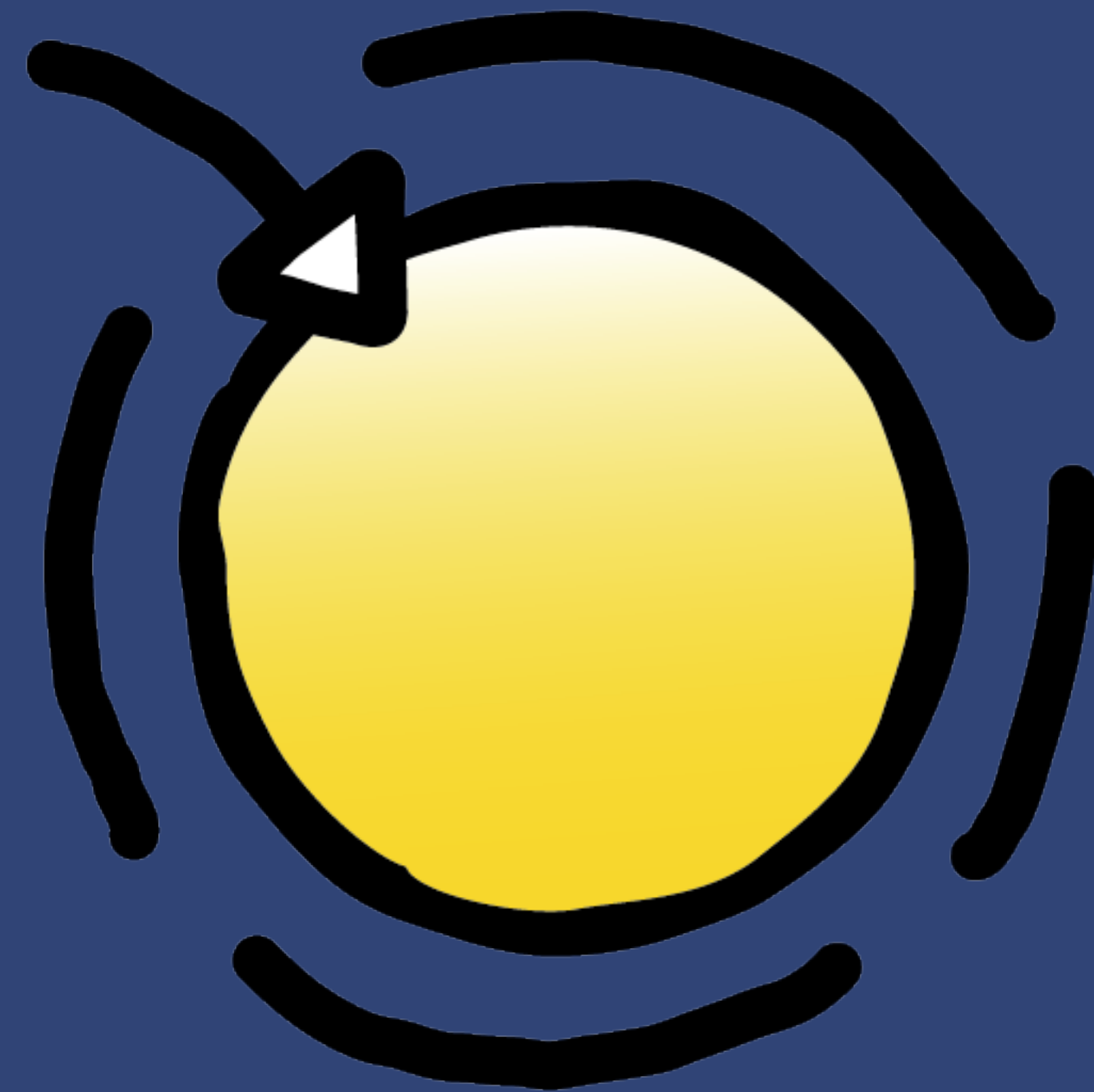
Faros—*AI Engineering Report 2026: The Acceleration Whiplash*



22K devs, 4K teams

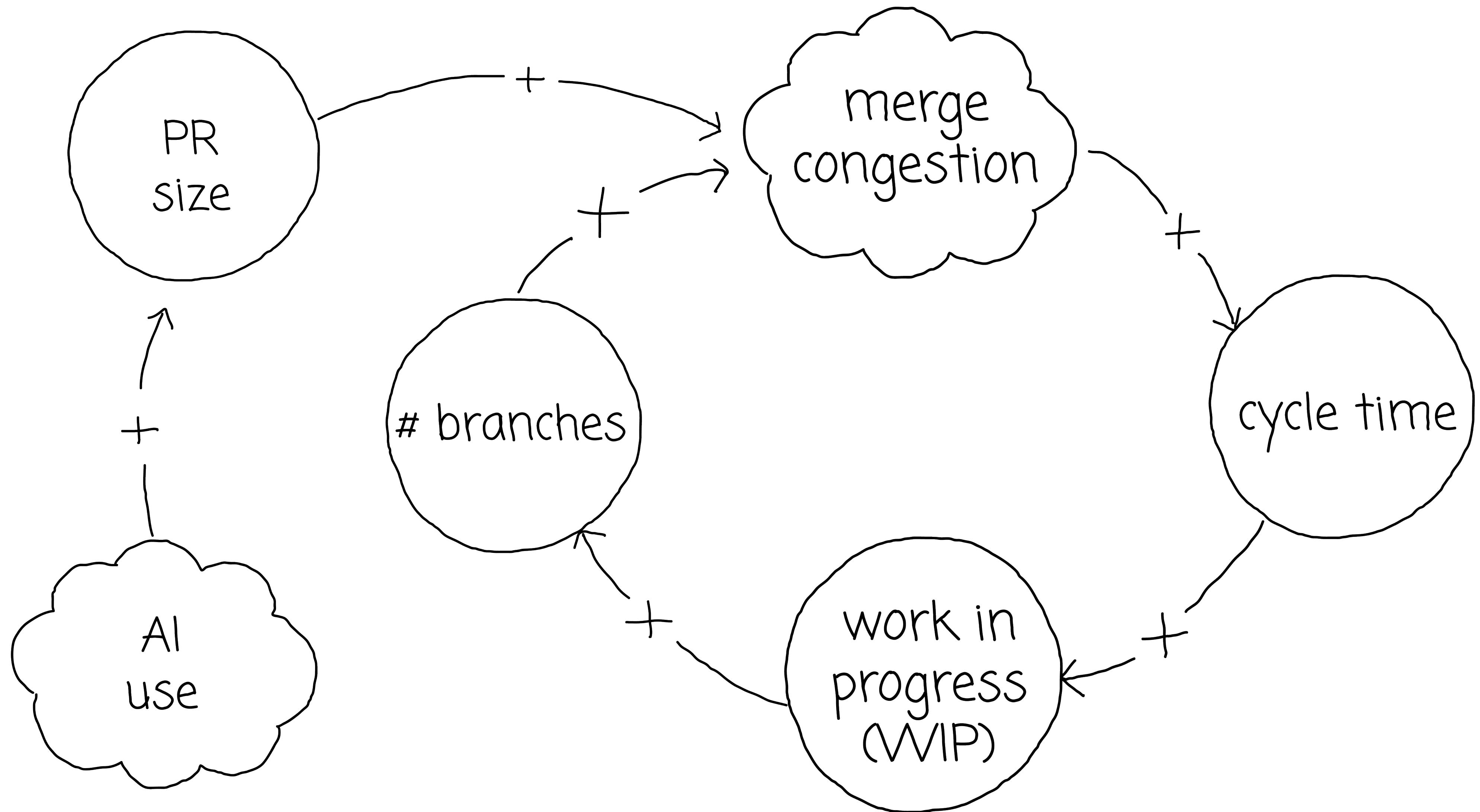
Illusion of progress



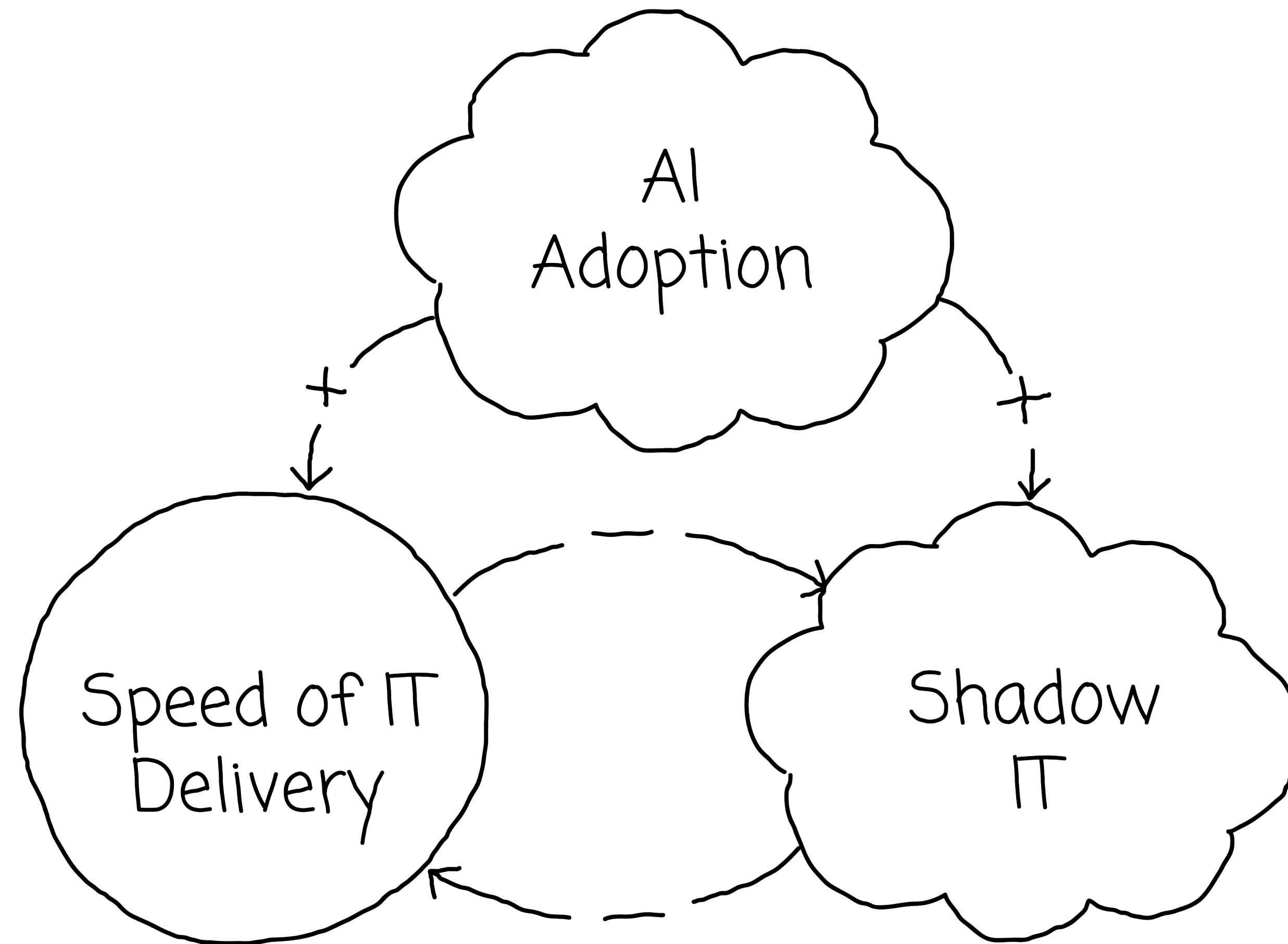


Unintended Consequences

Cycle time and merge queues



Shadow IT leading to unplanned maintenance burden



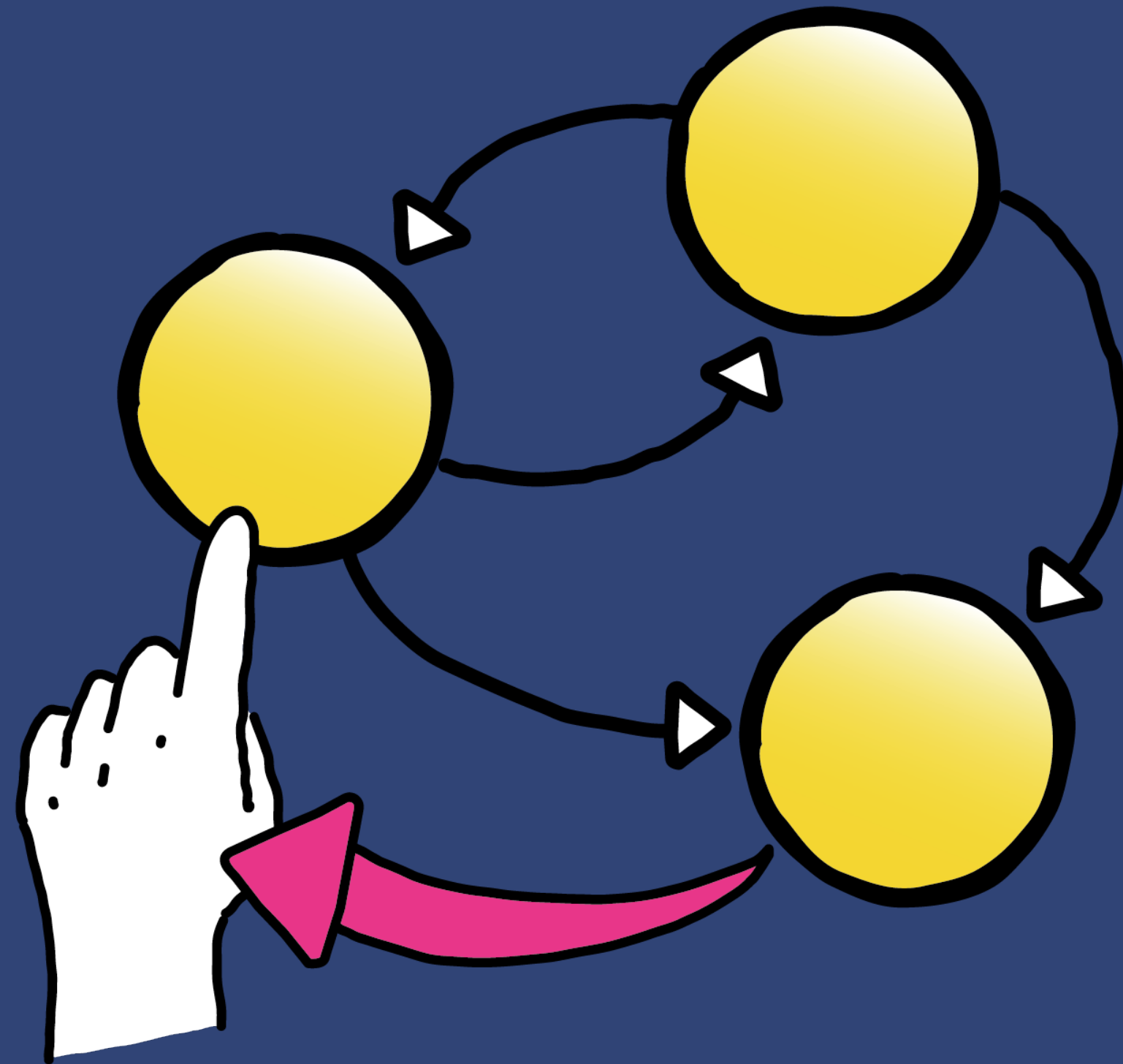


AI is
an amplifier

It multiplies everything:

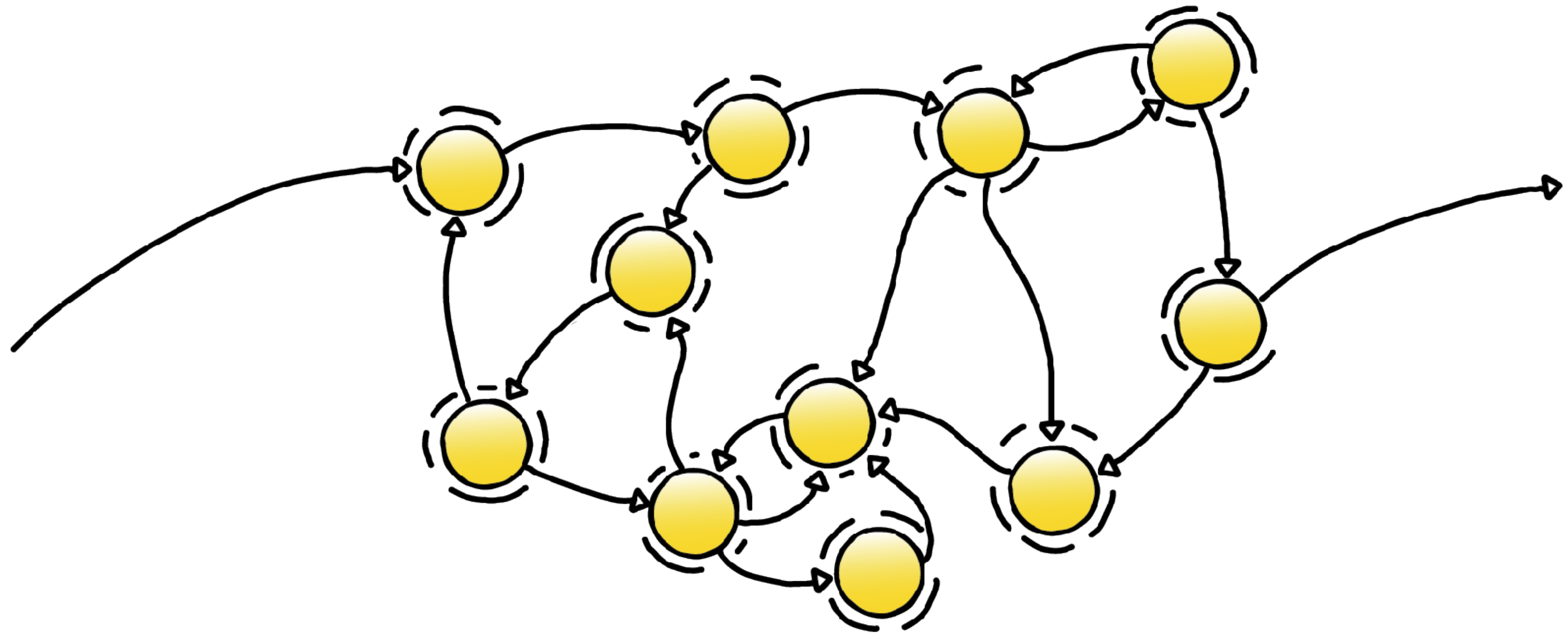
- Benefits
- Impediments
- Bottlenecks
- Noise
- Chaos

you poke the system



the system pokes back

Software delivery is an adaptive sociotechnical system

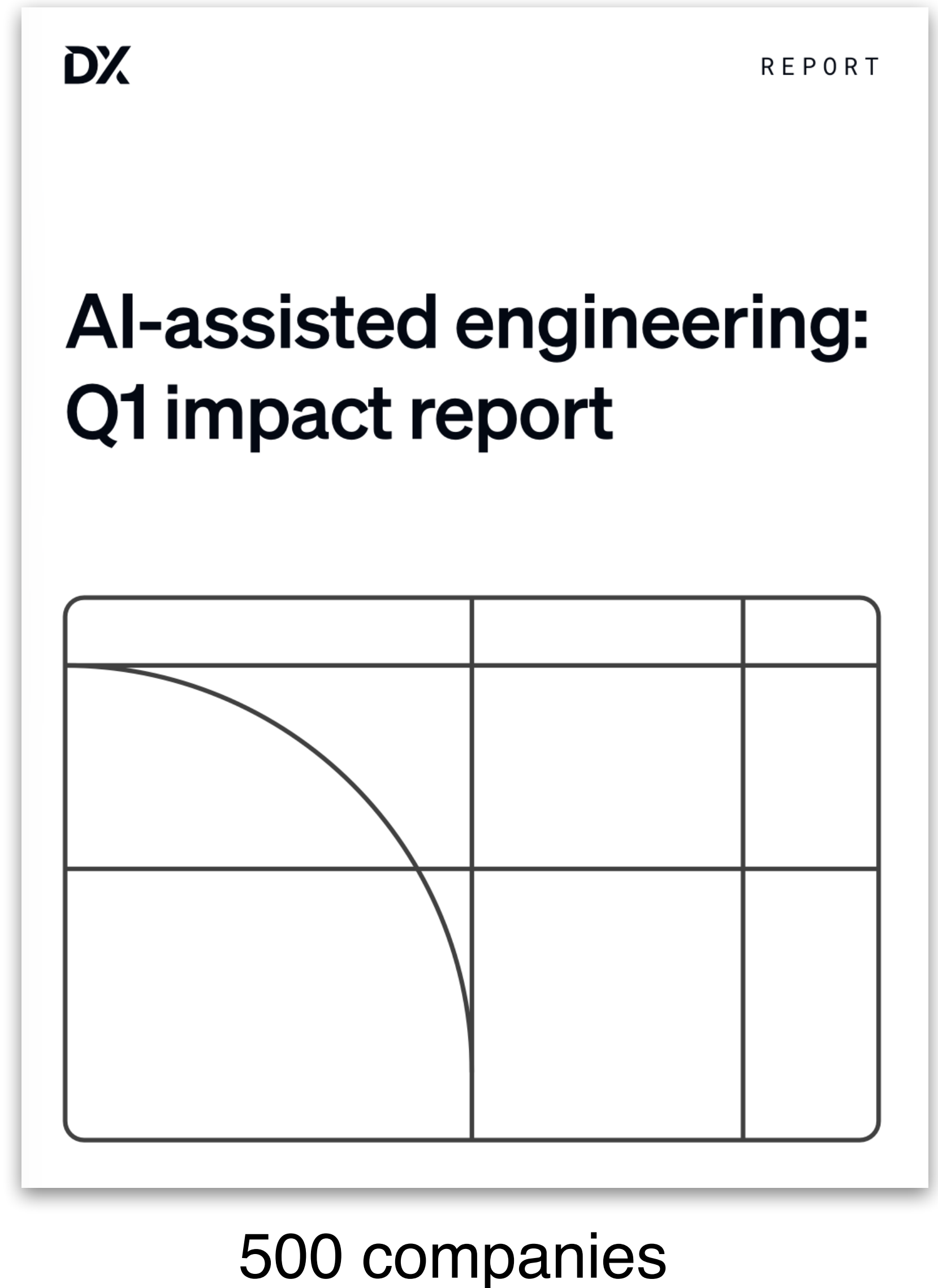


“In any system, when one improves the performance of the parts taken separately, the performance of the whole does not necessarily improve and frequently gets worse.”

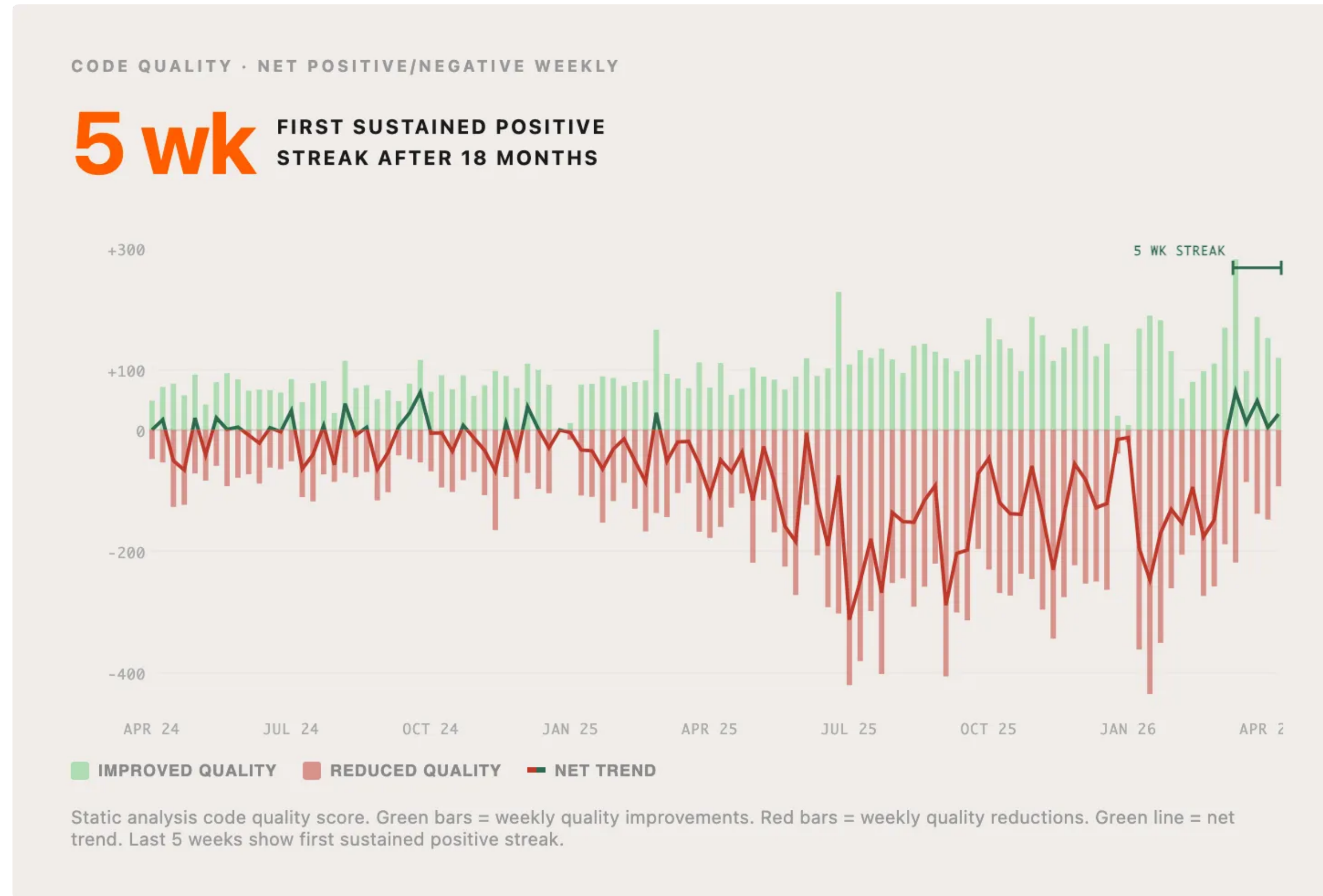
— Russell Ackoff

“While some organizations are seeing clear improvement to quality as AI usage increases, others are seeing serious degradation, with many swinging significantly.”

*DX—AI-Assisted Engineering: 2026
Q1 Impact Report*



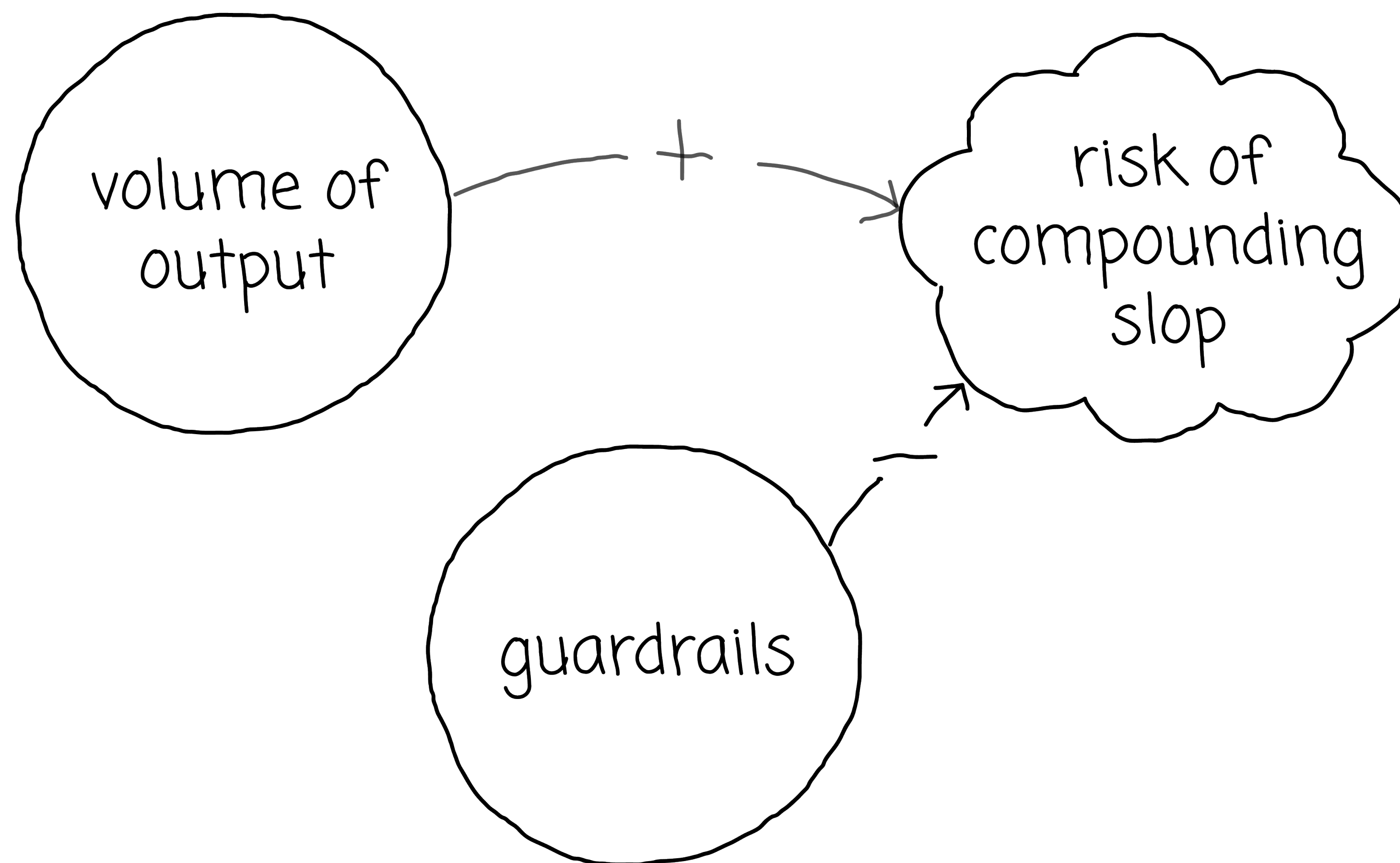
Case study: Darragh Curran on 2x-ing at Intercom



Quality got worse
before it got better

Source: <https://ideas.fin.ai/p/2x-nine-months-later>

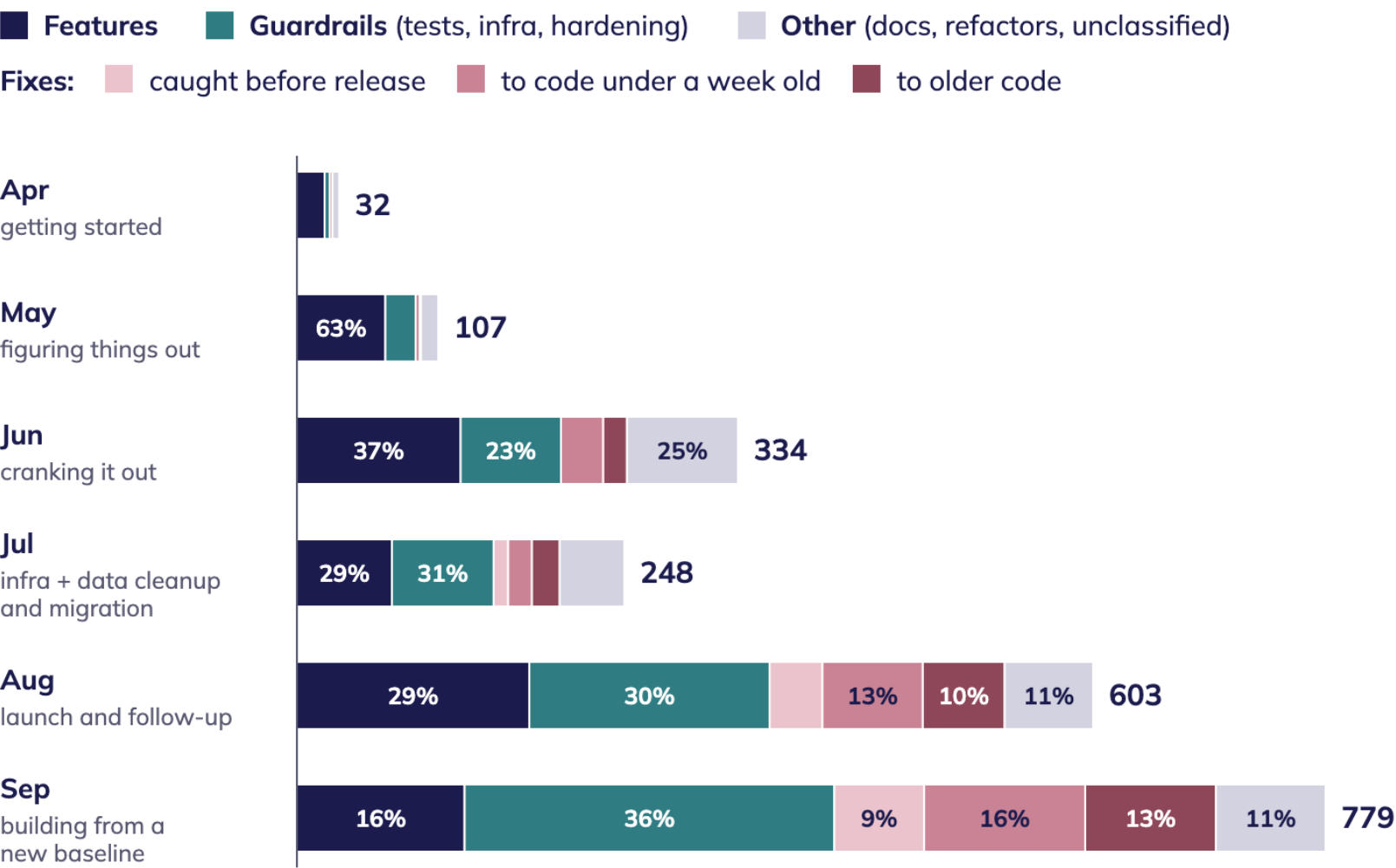
Insufficient guardrails



Case study: Cate Huston on replatforming Twill

Six months of merged PRs

What two engineers and a software factory shipped at Twill, by kind of work.

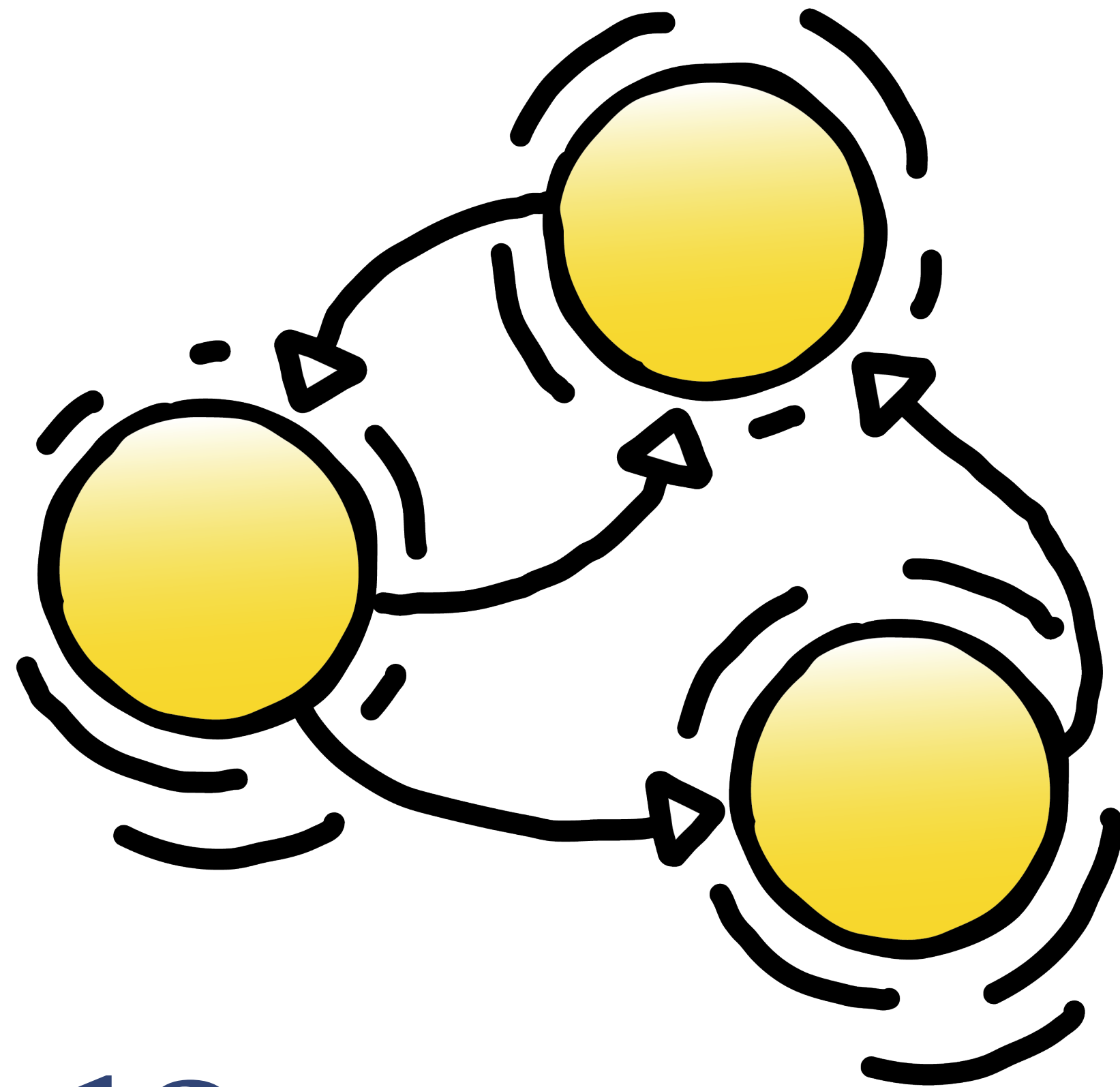


Source: Twill GitHub, merged PRs Apr 1 – Sep 30 2026 (2,103 PRs). Fixes split by when the code they change first reached production. 'Caught before release' starts in July, when releases became a gate rather than every PR shipping straight to production.

PRs up 24x!

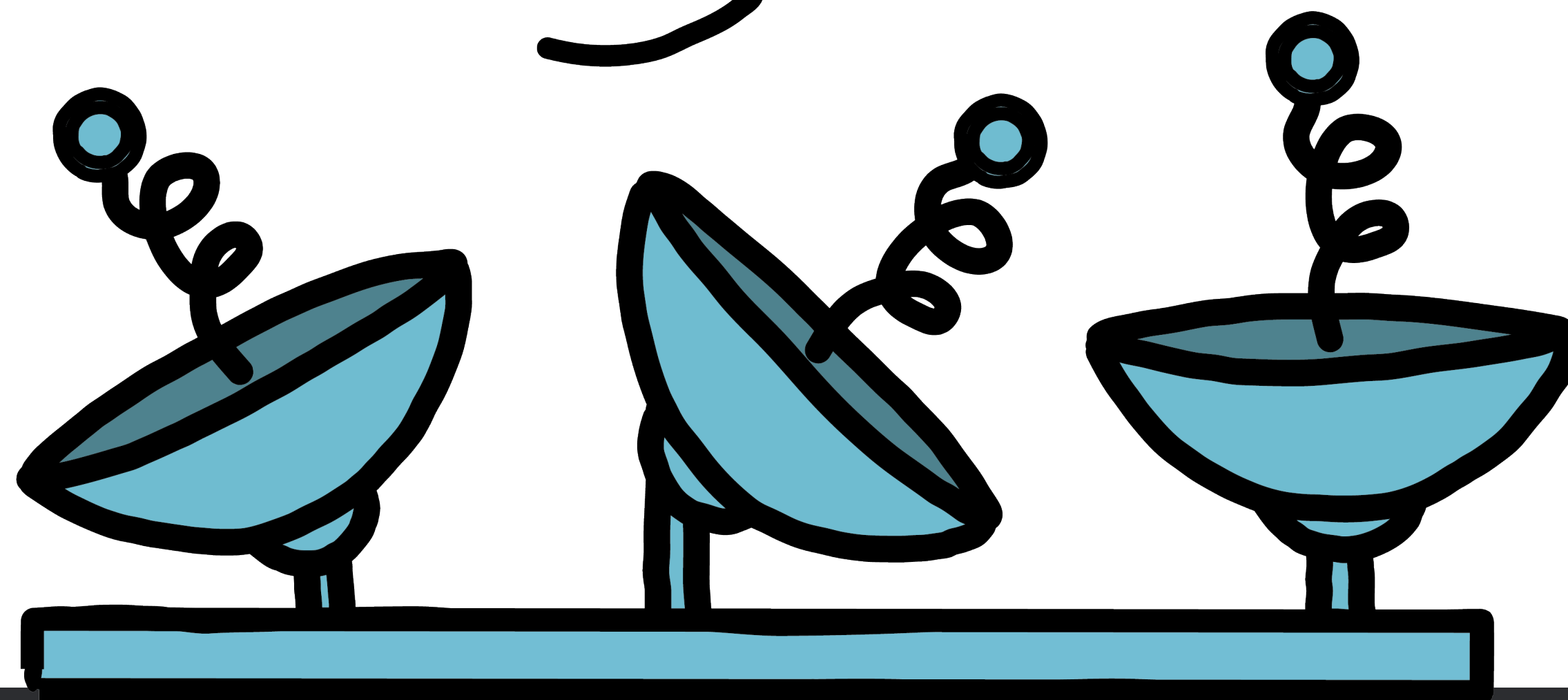
but...rework is also up

Source: <https://cate.blog/2026/10/06/is-the-software-factory-working/>



Signal?

Noise?



So...now what?

Measure outcomes (*not unproven proxies or vanity metrics*)

productivity

value delivered
*(not lines of
code, tokens
used, or PRs)*

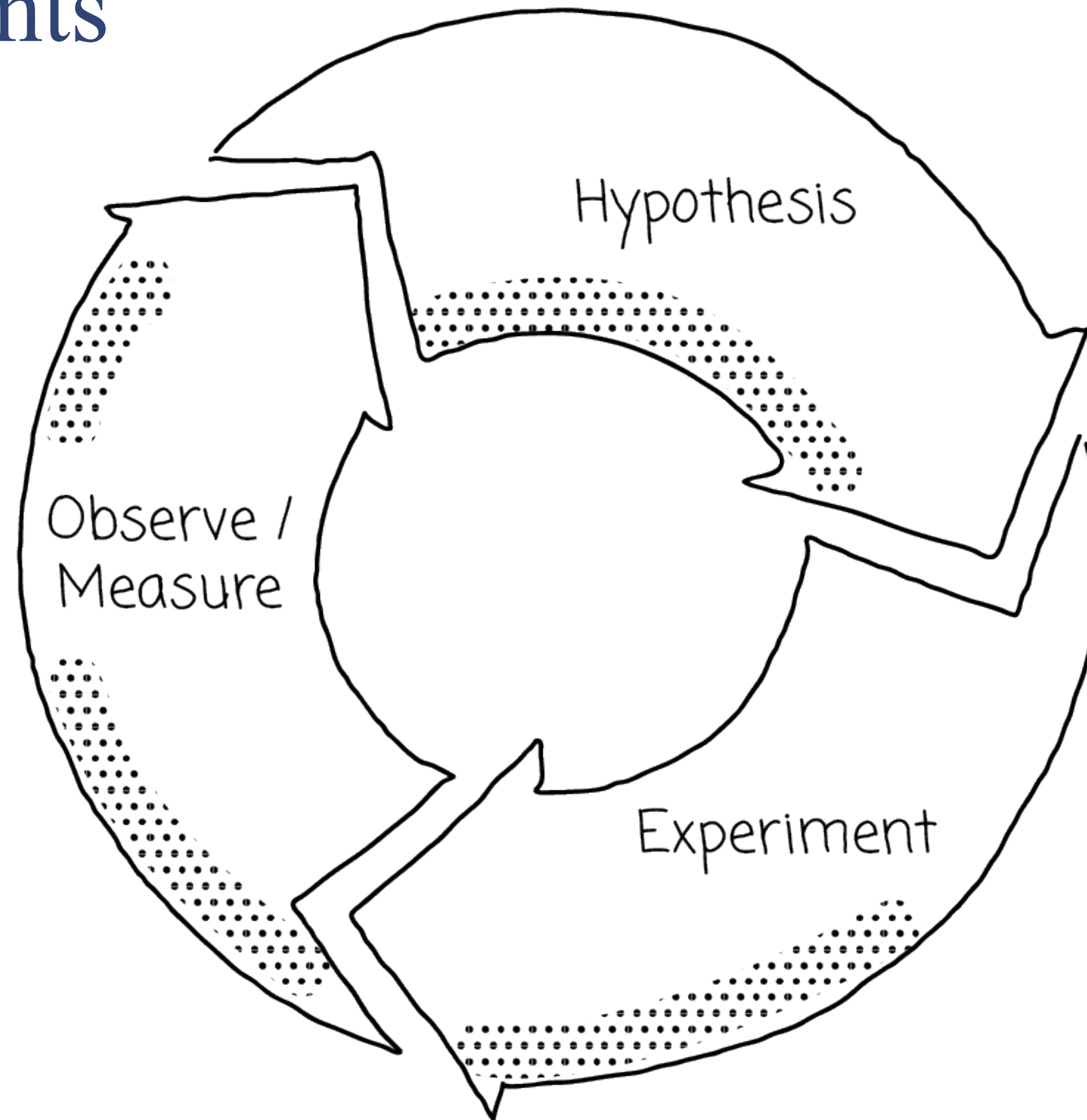
quality

prod failures &
incidents
*(not interim
rework)*

financials

revenue,
all-in costs
*(not just token
cost or salary
cost)*

Design experiments



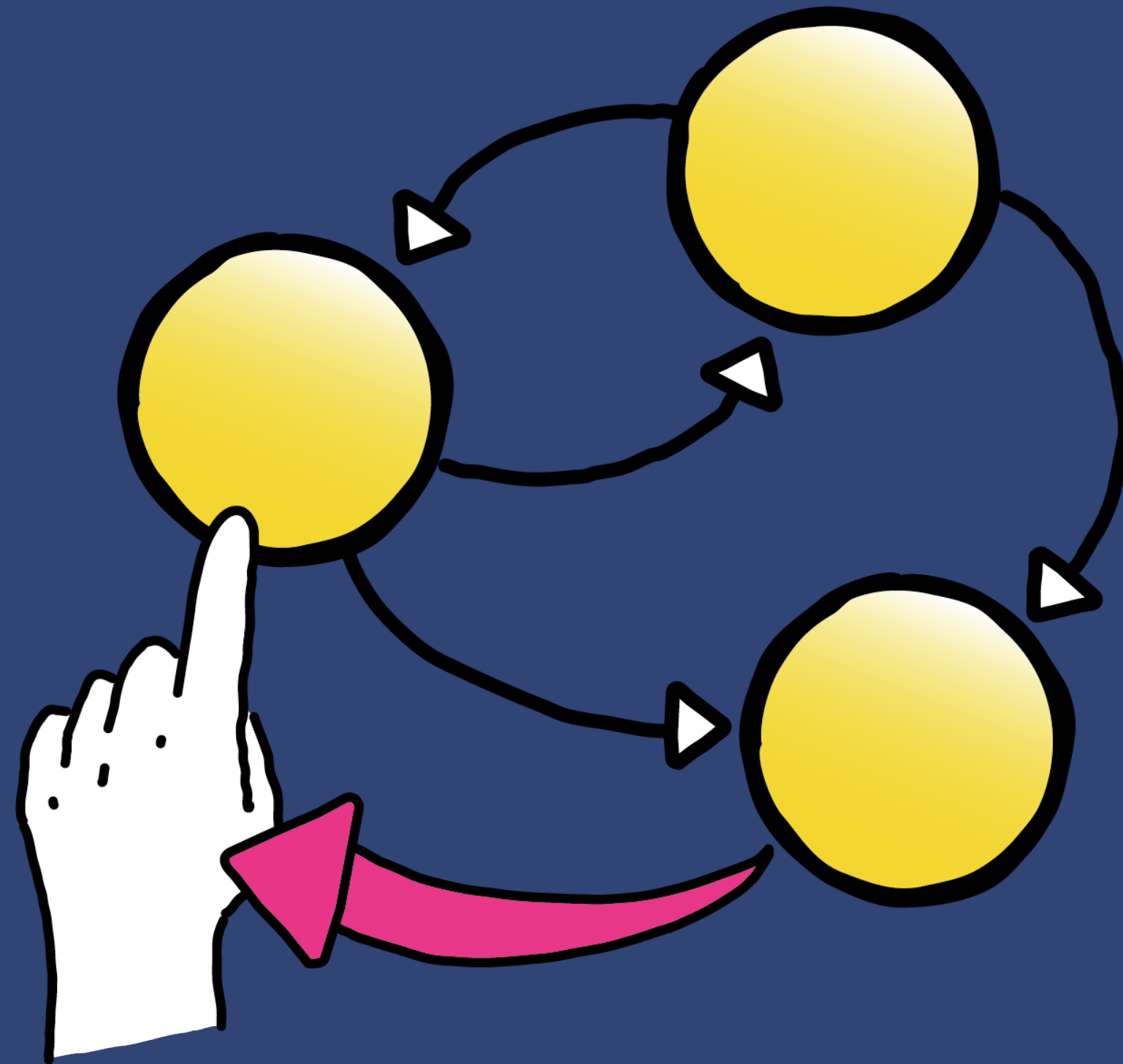
Invest in guardrails

“...building software still demands discipline, but the discipline shows up more in the scaffolding rather than the code. The tooling, abstractions, and feedback loops that keep the codebase coherent are increasingly important.”

– Ryan Lopopolo, OpenAI

Source: <https://openai.com/index/harness-engineering/>

and remember... you poke the system



the system pokes back

help please

I want to hear your stories.
*(I especially love good stories about
ironic unintended consequences.)*